

The Research Proposal

What is a Proposal?

- A proposal is a written report that seeks to persuade the reader to accept a suggested plan of action.

Types of proposals

- Project proposals- A Project proposal can also persuade a foundation to fund a project to be undertaken by the writer's firm.
- Business Plans
- Research Proposal
- Sales Proposal

Internal and External Proposals

- Internal proposals are written to a decision maker in your own organization.
- External proposals are sent to a decision maker outside your company.

Internal Proposals writing

- Internal Proposals have four parts:
 1. *Purpose*. Begin with a brief statement of why you are writing the proposal.
 2. *Problem*. Prove that a problem exists by documenting its importance for your boss and the company.
 3. *Solution*. Describe the change you want approved.

Internal Proposals cont.

4. *Conclusion*. Make this section short-no more than two paragraphs. Remind the reader that the problem is serious, the reason for change is justified, and action needs to be taken.

Re-emphasize the most important benefits of your proposed solution.

External Proposals

- Sales proposals are the most common type of external proposal. Most sales proposals include the following elements:
 1. *Introduction*. This section may include a statement of purpose and background information on the problem you propose to solve

External Proposals cont.

2. *Description of the product or service*. This section is the heart of your proposal. It needs to provide hard evidence that what you propose can and should be done.
3. *Timetable*.
4. *Costs*.

External Proposals continued.

5. **Qualifications** of your company.
Emphasize your company's accomplishments and expertise.
6. **Conclusion**. This section contains your "call to action," where you encourage your reader to approve your plan.

External Proposals ex.

- The format of these external documents may be a letter report, a manuscript report, or even a form report, with the form supplied by the soliciting organization.

Research proposal

- A research proposal is a structured presentation of what you plan to do in research, why you plan to conduct the research, and how you plan to accomplish it.

Purpose of the Research Proposal

- To present the question to be researched and its importance
- To discuss the research efforts of others who have worked on related questions (Literature Review)
- To suggest the data necessary for solving the question

Benefits of the Proposal to a Researcher

- Allows the researcher to plan and review the project's steps
- Serves as a guide throughout the investigation.
 - A review of management and research literature in developing the proposal encourages the researcher to assess previous approaches to similar management questions and revise the research plan accordingly.
- Forces time and budget estimates

Types of Research Proposals: Internal and External

- **Internal**
 - Internal proposals are short and snappy; a one to three-page memo from the researcher to management outlining the problem statement, study objectives, research design, and schedule is enough to start an exploratory study.
 - In the small scale proposal, the literature review is not stressed and can be stated briefly in the research design.

Types of Research Proposals contd.

- **External**
 - An external proposal is either solicited or unsolicited.
 - A solicited proposal is developed in response to a request for proposals (RFP), and is likely to compete against several others for the contract or grant.
 - An unsolicited proposal represents a suggestion by a contract researcher for a research that might be done. Such proposals do not compete against others.

Proposal Complexity

- **3 levels of complexity:**
 - The *exploratory study* is used for the most simple proposals
 - The *small-scale study* is more complex and common in business
 - The *large-scale professional study* is the most complex, costing millions of dollars

Modules in a Research Proposal

- Executive Summary
- Problem Statement
- Research Objectives
- Literature Review
- Importance of the Study
- Research Design
- Data Analysis
- Nature and Form of Results
- Qualifications of Researcher
- Budget
- Schedule
- Facilities and Special Resources
- Project Management
- Bibliography
- Appendices

RP Modules: Executive Summary

- Executive Summary is essentially an informative abstract, giving executives the chance to grasp the essentials of the proposal without having to read the details.
- It should include brief statements of the management dilemma and management question, the research objectives/research question(s), and the benefits of your approach.
- If the proposal is unsolicited (voluntary, uncalled for) a brief description of your qualifications is also appropriate.

RP Modules: Executive Summary

- Internal proposals are more concise (to the point) than external ones. A one-three page memo from the researcher to management outlining the problem statement, study objectives, research design, and schedule is enough to start an exploratory study.
- An external proposal is either solicited or unsolicited. A solicited proposal is often in response to an RFP.

RP Modules: Problem Statement

- Statement of the management dilemma, its background, its consequences, and the resulting management question clearly without the use of idioms.
- Any areas of the management question that will not be addressed should also be included in this section.

RP Modules: Research Objectives

- This module addresses the purpose of investigation. Laying out exactly what is being planned by the proposed research.
 - In a descriptive study, the objectives can be stated as the research question. The research question can be further broken down into investigative questions. If the proposal is for a causal study, the objectives can be stated as a hypothesis.
- The objectives module flows naturally from the problem statement, giving the sponsor specific, concrete, and achievable goals.
- The research question or hypothesis, if appropriate should be separated from the flow of the text for quick identification.

RP Modules: Research Objectives contd.

- The research objectives section is the basis for judging the remainder of the proposal and, ultimately, the final report.
- This section verifies the consistency of the proposal by checking to see that each objective is discussed in the research design, data analysis, and results section.

Literature Review

- This section examines recent (or historically significant) research studies, company data, or industry reports that act as a basis for the proposed study.
- Begin your discussion of the related literature and relevant secondary data from a comprehensive perspective, moving to more specific studies that are associated with your problem.
- If the problem has a historical background, begin with the earliest references.

Literature Review contd.

- Avoid details (no comprehensive report) and give a brief review of literature.
- Always refer to the original source.
- Emphasize the important results and conclusions of other studies, the relevant data and trends from previous research, and particular methods or design that could be duplicated or should be avoided.
- Discuss how the literature applies to the study you are proposing; show the weaknesses or faults in the design, discussing how you would avoid similar problems.

Literature Review contd.

- If your proposal deals solely with secondary data, discuss the relevance of data and the bias or lack of bias in it.
- Close the literature review section by summarizing the important aspects of the literature and interpreting them in terms of your problem.
- Refine the problem as necessary in the light of your findings.

Importance of the Study

- Importance/benefits of the study depends on the needs for the research.
- Research cannot solve a potential unionization problem.
- Your research can help the management in responding to employees concerns and forge a linkage between those concerns and unionization.

Research Design

- The design module describes what you are going to do in technical terms.
- It provides information on your proposal design for tasks such as sample selection and size, data collection method, instrumentation, procedures, and ethical requirements.
- It discusses the method you have rejected and why your selected approach is superior.

Data Analysis

- A brief section on the methods used for analyzing the data is appropriate for large scale contract research projects and doctoral thesis.
- With smaller projects, the proposed data analysis would be included within the research design section.
- It is in this section that you describe your proposed handling of the data and the theoretical basis for using selected techniques.

Data Analysis contd.

- This module is often a tough section to write. You can make it easier to write, read, and understand your data analysis by using sample charts and tables featuring “dummy” data.
- The data analysis section is so important to evaluating contract research proposals that the researcher should contract an expert to review the latest techniques available for use in the particular research study and compare these to the proposed techniques.

Nature and Form of Research

- Upon finishing this section, the sponsor should be able to go back to the statement of the management question and research objectives and discover that each goal of the study has been covered.
- One should also specify the types of data to be obtained and the interpretations that will be made in the analysis.

Qualifications of Researchers

- This section should begin with the principal investigator, and then provide similar information on all individuals involved with the project. Two elements are critical:
 - Professional research competence (relevant research experience, the highest academic degree held, and membership in business and technical societies).
 - Relevant management experience.

Budget

- The budget should be presented in the form the sponsor requests.
- The budget statement in an internal research proposal is based on employee and overhead costs.
- The budget presented by an external research organization is not just the wages or salaries of its employees but the person/hour price that the contracting firm charges.

Schedule

- The schedule should include major phases of the project, their timetables, and the milestones that signify the completion of a phase.
 - For example, major phase may be i) exploratory interviews, ii) final research proposal, iii) questionnaire revision, iv) field interviews, v) editing and coding, vi) data analysis, and vii) report generation.
 - Each of these phases should have an estimated time schedule and people assigned to work. Chart your schedule using
 - CPM if the project is large.

Facilities and Special Resources

- Often, projects will require special facilities or resources, for instance, a contract exploratory study may need specialized facilities for focus group sessions. Computer-assisted telephone or other interviewing facilities may be required.
- Alternatively, your proposed data analysis may require sophisticated computer algorithms, and therefore, you need access to an adequate system.
- These requirements will vary from study to study. The proposal should carefully list the relevant facilities and resources that will be used.
- The costs for such facility use should be detailed in your budget.

Project Management

- The purpose of this section is to show to the sponsor that the research team is organized in a way to do the project efficiently.
- A master plan is required for complex projects to show how all the phases will be brought together. The plan includes:
 - The research team organization;
 - Management procedure and controls for executing the research plan;
 - Examples of management and technical reports;
 - The research team's relationships with the sponsor;
 - Financial and legal responsibility; and
 - Management competence

Bibliography

Use the appropriate and required format for listing references.

Referencing

- The research paper should follow an academic style of referencing.
- There are four referencing systems from which to choose (Butcher 1981), and
- You need to adopt the one that is acceptable to your university and academic discipline.

Referencing

- ‘The first of these is used in most general books; the second mainly in science and social science books; the third and fourth less frequently’ (Butcher 1981, p.167).
- The four referencing systems are:
 - The short-title system;
 - The author-date system;
 - The reference by number system;
 - The author-number system.

Writing a Bibliography

- There are several well-established systems for writing a bibliography and your choice is dependent upon the preference of the discipline and university.
- In the social sciences, some of the most commonly used ones are (Longyear 1983, p.83):
 - The Harvard system,
 - The American Psychological Association system;

Bibliography Writing Systems

- The American Medical Association System;
- The McGraw-Hill System;
- The Modern Languages Association System;
- The footnote system.

What to include in the Appendices?

- A glossary of concepts, constructs, and definitions
- Samples of the measurement instrument
- Other materials that reinforce the body of the proposal